



INNOVATIVE

LEARNING PARTNERSHIP



Primary Playbook: ILP Strands



ACCESSIBILITY AND ADAPTATION

DIRECT INSTRUCTION

INDEPENDENT PRACTICE

ASSESSMENT

FEEDBACK

WORKFLOW – SIMPLE AND SAFE

Introduction

The Innovative Learning Partnership (ILP) is built around four strands that describe what effective teaching looks like across Nova schools — **Direct Instruction, Independent Practice, Assessment and Feedback.**

These ILP strands represent the core elements of great teaching. They aren't a checklist or a prescribed order, but a shared language and structure that help teachers plan, teach and adapt learning with clarity and purpose.

Each strand explains what strong practice looks and feels like in the classroom, drawing on research from Barak Rosenshine, the Education Endowment Foundation (EEF), Clare Gadsby and others.

Every section includes:

1. **Descriptor** — what the strand means in practice.
2. **Teaching techniques and examples** — what teachers do and what pupils do.

3. **EYFS application** — how it looks in the Early Years.
4. **SEND adaptation** — how to ensure access for all learners.
5. **Digital amplification** — how technology can strengthen the process.
6. **Research links** — connecting classroom practice to proven principles.

The strands are designed to work in combination. In a single lesson, teachers might model and explain new content, check understanding, provide feedback and support pupils to practise independently. The order is less important than the intentional use of each strand to help pupils learn well and retain knowledge securely.

Across Nova schools, these strands give a consistent foundation for classroom practice while allowing teachers the freedom to bring their own expertise, subject knowledge and creativity to their teaching.

ILP Strand: Direct Instruction

Descriptor — What It Looks Like in Practice

Effective Direct Instruction means pupils know exactly what they are learning, why it matters and how to succeed. It involves clear explanations, purposeful modelling and guided practice before independence.

At its best, it looks calm, deliberate and interactive. The teacher breaks down new content into small, manageable steps, checking that pupils are following and adapting as needed. They make their thinking visible — showing not just what to do, but how to think.

Direct Instruction isn't about teacher talk for long periods; it's about shared thinking. The teacher leads pupils through the early stages of learning with clarity, structure and high expectations, ensuring everyone has a secure starting point before moving on.

Teaching Techniques and Examples

Clarity of Explanation

- Begin every new learning point with a clear statement of what pupils are about to learn and why it matters.
Example: "Today we're learning how to write complex sentences so we can make our writing more detailed."
- Use simple, precise language and short sentences. Avoid unnecessary detail at the start — depth comes later.
- Check understanding regularly by asking pupils to restate key ideas in their own words.

Modelling and Demonstration

- Model the process step by step, explaining your thinking as you go (Rosenshine, 2012).
Example: "I'm joining these two clauses with 'because' — that tells the reader why something happened."
- Show both correct and incorrect examples so pupils see what success and error look like.
- Use visuals or diagrams to support explanation (dual coding — Paivio, 1986).
Example: Draw a labelled diagram or highlight key parts of a sentence as you explain them.*

Guided Practice and Scaffolding

- Move gradually from demonstration to guided practice ("I do — We do — You do").
- Work through examples together before expecting independence.
- Provide scaffolds such as sentence starters, worked examples, or visual guides — then remove them as pupils become more confident.
- Encourage pupils to verbalise their reasoning before writing or completing tasks.

Questioning and Checking for Understanding

- Use strategies like cold calling, no hands up and mini whiteboards to ensure everyone responds.
- Allow time for thinking — at least three seconds before taking an answer.

- Follow up with probing questions: “How do you know?” or “Can you explain it another way?”
- If misconceptions appear, pause and reteach clearly before moving on.

Pupil Engagement

- Build short “turn and talk” moments to rehearse understanding before responding publicly.
- Revisit key learning through quick recall activities or recap quizzes.
- Praise effort, precision and improvement rather than speed.

Adapting for the Early Years

- Use short, frequent inputs with clear, simple language.
- Model vocabulary through everyday contexts — “I’m pouring the water until it reaches the top.”
- Demonstrate new skills through play (Strong Foundations, Ofsted 2024).
- Repeat and revisit often — children need multiple exposures.
- Use songs, stories and gestures to reinforce understanding.
- Encourage children to explain what they are doing in their own words.

Adapting for Pupils with SEND

- Start with what pupils already know — link new learning to familiar ideas.

- Keep explanations short and supported with visuals or gestures.
- Model step by step and provide one task at a time.
- Give time for processing before expecting a response.
- Use multi-sensory approaches — saying, showing and doing together.
- Provide overlearning opportunities and celebrate small gains.
- Maintain ambition but adjust the route: fewer steps, not lower expectations.

Amplifying Through Digital Technology

- Showbie: share models and success criteria for pupils to revisit.
- Apple Classroom: monitor understanding live and support discreetly.
- Screen Recorder: record live modelling so pupils can replay it.
- Freeform: Use AR and live modelling freely.
- Accessibility tools (text-to-speech, overlays, voice notes): ensure all pupils can access content.

Digital tools make modelling visible, repeatable and accessible to all learners.

Research Links

Rosenshine (2012); Hattie (2009); Paivio (1986); EEF (2021); Gadsby (2016); Chohan (2023).

ILP Strand: Independent Practice

Descriptor — What It Looks Like in Practice

- Independent Practice gives pupils time and structure to apply what they've been taught. It's when understanding becomes secure because pupils think hard for themselves and practise deliberately.
- The teacher ensures pupils are ready, then steps back — not to withdraw, but to observe, prompt and support thinking without taking over.
- It's purposeful and active. Pupils know what they're practising, why it matters and what success looks like. Over time, this builds fluency, confidence and independence.

Teaching Techniques and Examples

Clarity and Purpose

- Explain the purpose of the task and what pupils are practising.
- Keep tasks focused on one key skill at a time to avoid overload (Sweller, 1988).
- Ensure pupils can articulate what they're doing before they start.

From Guided to Independent

- Use the gradual release model: "I do — We do — You do — You reflect."
- Check readiness before setting pupils off: "Can you explain it to someone else?"

- Keep visual prompts or success criteria on display (dual coding — Paivio, 1986).

Deliberate Practice

- Design tasks that make pupils think and apply, not just repeat.
- Example: "Write your own example that shows this method."
- Include retrieval and interleaving to revisit prior learning (Bjork, 2011).
- Encourage pupils to explain their thinking aloud or in writing.
- Use prompts instead of giving answers: "What's your next step?"

Building Self-Regulation

- Teach pupils to plan and check their work: "What do I need to do first?"
- Provide reflection pauses: "Stop and check — does this make sense?"
- Encourage perseverance and celebrate improvement.

Teacher Role During Practice

- Circulate, observe and note patterns — avoid over-helping.
- Offer short prompts: "Check that step again."
- Adapt scaffolds or plan for a follow-up if gaps appear.

Adapting for the Early Years

- Independence grows through guided play and repetition.
- Adults prompt children to try again or explain what they're doing.
- Keep expectations clear and visual.
- Praise persistence and small successes.
- Use stories, songs and routines to reinforce independence.

Adapting for Pupils with SEND

- Scaffold tasks carefully with clear steps and visuals.
- Provide fewer choices to reduce cognitive load.
- Allow verbal rehearsal before recording.
- Offer multiple ways to respond — drawing, typing, or speaking.
- Use frequent check-ins to keep momentum.
- Repeat and reinforce to secure fluency.

Amplifying Through Digital Technology

- Showbie: pupils upload and redraft work with feedback.
- Stylus and Freeform: record working out or verbal reasoning.
- Adaptive apps (TTRS, Spelling Shed, Magma

Maths): personalise rehearsal.

- Screen recording: pupils explain what they've done and why.
- Accessibility tools: support independence for all.

Digital practice extends access, feedback and reflection beyond the classroom.

Research Links

Rosenshine (2012); Bjork (2011); Gadsby (2016); Sweller (1988); Paivio (1986); Chohan (2023); EEF (2021).

ILP Strand: Assessment

Descriptor — What It Looks Like in Practice

Assessment is woven through every lesson. It's how teachers find out what pupils know, understand and can do, then decide what to do next.

Effective assessment is responsive — it shapes teaching in real time. Teachers notice, question and adapt as they go. Pupils see assessment as part of learning, not a judgement.

When assessment works well, teachers have clear insight and pupils have clarity about their progress and next steps.

Teaching Techniques and Examples

Checking for Understanding

- Use cold calling, mini whiteboards, or hands down questioning to check all pupils' understanding.
- Allow wait time and follow up with "Why?" and "How do you know?" (Rowe, 1986).
- Reteach immediately if confusion is evident.

Dialogue as Assessment

- Listen carefully to pupil talk — it reveals understanding.
- Build "turn and talk" and "explain it back" moments.
- Use open-ended questions: "What would happen if...?" "Can you show another way?"

Retrieval and Review

- Start lessons with retrieval of prior learning (start with cued retrieval and build to free retrieval).
- Include questions that mix new and old content (Bjork, 2011).
- Celebrate recall to reinforce confidence and memory.

Responsive Teaching

- Use what you see to make live adjustments.
- Share common errors openly and reteach.
- Record notes on who may need further practice.

Supporting Pupil Self-Assessment

- Make success criteria visible and clear.
- Model how to self-check work against goals.
- Use exit tickets or "What went well / next time" reflections.
- Provide exemplars so pupils can see what success looks like.

Assessing Foundational Knowledge and Core Literacy Skills

Assessment should always start with a clear grasp of what sits at the foundation of learning. In every subject, pupils' ability to demonstrate understanding depends on secure foundational knowledge and strong literacy skills — particularly reading, writing and oracy.

Teachers need to be explicit about what this means within their subject:

- **Reading** — Do pupils understand the key vocabulary, texts and information they are expected to work with? Can they interpret subject-specific language accurately?
- **Writing** — Can pupils communicate ideas clearly using the conventions of the subject (e.g. writing a method in science, or a justified opinion in history)?
- **Oracy** — Are pupils able to explain, discuss and reason verbally using precise language? Do they use talk to organise and test their thinking?

In practice, this means:

- Checking that pupils can decode and comprehend the materials they're reading before assessing higher-order understanding.
- Embedding short, frequent checks on key vocabulary, sentence structure and disciplinary language.
- Listening to how pupils explain their reasoning — clear talk is often the best indicator of genuine understanding.
- Using written and verbal responses to reveal gaps in background knowledge or misconceptions.
- Teaching and assessing literacy skills in context rather than as an add-on: for example, evaluating a history paragraph for both factual accuracy and clarity of explanation.

(Research link: *EEF Literacy Guidance Reports; Rosenshine's focus on prior knowledge; Willingham, 2009 — "Reading and background knowledge"; Alex Quigley, 2018 — "Closing the Vocabulary Gap."*)

Understanding and Assessing the 'Big Ideas'

High-quality assessment isn't about testing isolated facts — it's about seeing how pupils are building understanding of the big ideas that underpin each subject.

These big ideas act as the conceptual threads running through the curriculum: cause and consequence in history, place and environment in geography, structure and number in maths, or audience and purpose in writing.

Building on work with Jonathon Lear, effective teachers assess learning against these ideas over time, not just within single lessons. They ask:

- "What is the big idea here?"
- "How does this new learning connect to what came before?"
- "Can pupils apply it flexibly in new contexts?"

Practical ways to assess against big ideas:

- Use concept maps or schema walls to show how current learning connects to previous units.
- Design cumulative tasks that require pupils to draw on several prior pieces of knowledge.
- Pose transfer questions — "Would this still be true if...?" — to check depth of understanding.
- Review written and verbal explanations for evidence of connection-making rather than recall alone.

- Keep a running picture of each pupil's understanding through notes, retrieval data and pupil dialogue — what Jonathon Lear described as "building a picture, not giving a grade."

Big-idea assessment gives purpose to day-to-day checking. It ensures we are evaluating whether pupils can think with their knowledge, not just remember it.

(Research link: *Jonathon Lear — "The Monkey Proof Box" (2017); Ofsted (2022) — Curriculum research review series; Bruner, 1960 — "Spiral Curriculum" concept.*)

Adapting for the Early Years

- Assessment happens through observation and conversation.
- Watch how children use skills in play and exploration.
- Use evidence like photos, notes and voice recordings.
- Focus on progress and next steps, not isolated outcomes.
- Build warm relationships so children show what they know confidently.

Adapting for Pupils with SEND

- Offer multiple ways to demonstrate understanding — oral, visual, or physical.
- Rephrase questions and allow processing time.
- Capture small steps of progress over time.
- Minimise cognitive overload — assess fewer

things well.

- Use support staff to help interpret pupil responses accurately.

Amplifying Through Digital Technology

- Showbie: collect evidence and give real-time feedback.
- Apple Classroom: monitor pupil progress live.
- Showbie Assessments: run quick checks to reveal understanding and analyse responses.
- Magma Maths: record pupils explaining their reasoning.
- AI tools: support with marking writing.
- Quest Progress: Utilise Gap analysis and age benchmarking from digital assessments in Reading and Maths.
- Microsoft Reading Progress: Use to gain precise insights into children's fluency in reading.
- Accessibility tools: voice input and playback to aid expression.

Digital tools help make learning visible and inform timely adaptation.

Research Links

Rosenshine (2012); Wiliam (2011); Bjork (2011); Hattie (2009); Gadsby (2016); EEF (2021); Chohan (2023); Ofsted (2024).

ILP Strand: Feedback

Descriptor — What It Looks Like in Practice

Feedback is how pupils understand their progress and what to do next. It's a conversation that helps them improve, not just a comment on their work.

Good feedback is specific, timely and actionable. It helps pupils make immediate improvements and builds independence over time. Feedback happens during, not just after, learning — verbally, in writing, or digitally.

It's successful when pupils can show or explain how it helped them get better.

Teaching Techniques and Examples

Live and Verbal Feedback

- Give short, specific feedback during the lesson.
- Example: "You've chosen the right strategy — now check your units."
- Use simple cues (underline, symbol, highlight) to direct attention.
- Praise improvement and effort.
- Build in response time immediately.

Written Feedback

- Keep comments concise and focused on one improvement.
- Link to clear criteria and give time for pupil response.

- Model "before and after" examples to show impact.

Feed Up, Feed Back, Feed Forward

(Hattie & Timperley, 2007)

1. Feed Up: Clarify the goal.
2. Feed Back: Describe current performance.
3. Feed Forward: Give a clear next step.

Peer and Self-Feedback

- Use sentence stems: "You did well because..." / "Next time, try..."
- Provide success criteria for structure.
- Model how to give feedback that's kind, specific and helpful.
- Encourage pupils to self-check before handing work in.

Whole-Class Feedback

- Review common strengths and misconceptions together.
- Share good examples and discuss why they work.
- Use whole-class feedback sheets to reduce marking load.

Creating a Feedback Culture

- Normalise feedback as part of learning.
- Build routines where pupils expect and respond to it.

- Encourage pupils to explain how feedback improved their work.

Adapting for the Early Years

- Give feedback immediately and in context.
- Use specific praise: "You balanced all the blocks carefully."
- Demonstrate and model corrections physically.
- Use gestures, tone and modelling alongside talk.
- Keep feedback positive and confidence-building.

Adapting for Pupils with SEND

- Use clear, simple language and one focus at a time.
- Pair verbal feedback with visuals or demonstrations.
- Give time to process and respond.
- Focus on effort, strategy and small steps of progress.
- Use multiple formats: voice notes, icons, or manipulatives.
- Work with support staff to reinforce next steps.

Amplifying Through Digital Technology

- Showbie: use voice notes and annotations for personalised feedback.
- Stylus: model corrections and redrafting.

- Screen Recorder: create short videos explaining next steps.
- Voice Notes: add tone and nuance for clarity.
- Accessibility tools: support independence in responding to feedback.

Digital feedback should save time, increase clarity and help pupils act quickly.

Research Links

Hattie & Timperley (2007); Gadsby (2016); Rosenshine (2012); EEF (2021); Wiliam (2011); Chohan (2023); Ofsted (2024).

Notes





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Nova Education Trust

C09–C11, The Sir Colin Campbell Building, University of Nottingham Innovation Park
Triumph Road, Nottingham NG7 2TU

0115 807 7777 contact@novaeducationtrust.net www.novaeducationtrust.net

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